

Report on the outcomes of a Short-Term Scientific Mission¹

Action number: CA21129

Grantee name: *Barbora Bad'urová*

Details of the STSM

Title: *Opinions about AI generated and non-AI-generated media : cross-country study and ethical analysis*

Start and end date: 26/01/2026 to 15/02/2026

Description of the work carried out during the STSM

The goal of this STSM was to examine public opinions and trust-related evaluative attitudes about „traditional“ (non-AI) and AI-generated media through a cross-country comparative study and to expand this analysis by incorporating ethical perspectives, resulting in a joint publication.

The STSM was carried out during the 3 weeks at 2 different institutions in the UK – University of Leeds and University of Oxford.

During the first week (26/01/2026 - 31/01/2026) I visited University of Leeds and met with my host Celia Tsui who is an active member of COST Action OPINION. We discussed our joint article. Discussed data from Reuters study and longitudinal trends. The research combines empirical analysis of the Reuters Institute Digital News Report survey data (2016–2025) on media trust with theoretical and normative ethical analysis of trust in „traditional“ and AI-mediated news. We discussed possible directions of refinement of our abstract and joint article. We identified trends in empirical data. Refined research questions and hypotheses. And discussed the theoretical interpretation.

During the weeks 2 and 3 (01/02/2026-15/02/2026) I was hosted by the Institute for ethics in AI, University of Oxford. Which is one the leading research institutions in AI ethics. I discussed the topic of trust in relation also to AI media with the researchers of the institute. I got relevant feedback on the topic. I visited Oxford University Library where I could use the resources.

I attended also events of the Institute for ethics in AI as well as Internet Institute, University of Oxford which helped to broaden the perspective on the topic of the article. The seminars which were most relevant for the topic of the article were focused on chilling effects by J. Penney, use of AI in public administration by N. Frost; problem of undecided voters from the point of view of moral and political philosophy; agency in relation to AI focused on young people by L. Dias Duran, etc. I met and discussed

¹ This report is submitted by the grantee to the Action MC for approval and for claiming payment of the awarded grant. The Grant Awarding Coordinator coordinates the evaluation of this report on behalf of the Action MC and instructs the GH for payment of the Grant.

my topic with several researchers including very beneficial meeting with the director of the institute prof. Harcourt.

The institute currently deals with similar topics of AI media trust including postdoc activities as well as new project in cooperation with BBC – on young people’s trust towards AI media – “Truth and Trust – AI and Young People”. I established connection and discussed topic with the researchers.

I also initiated meeting at the Uehiro Center for Practical Ethics, University of Oxford as they are also dealing with topics of AI ethics. We discussed possible research overlap and future exchange of information especially about research activities.

The feedback regarding research on the problem of trust as evaluative opinion in media and AI media as context dependent had positive feedback. The researchers from Oxford expressed interest to keep in contact regarding further cooperation on the similar topics related to AI ethics.

Moreover, during the debates and meetings as well as in intranet listing of the institute the COST action OPINION and its goals, outputs as well website were promoted and met with very positive reactions thanks to the actions interdisciplinary and timely focus.

Description of the STSM main achievements and planned follow-up activities

Meeting with Celia Tsui at the University of Leeds was highly beneficial, leading to significant progress on our article and extended abstract. The article examines the varieties of trust in traditional and AI-mediated news in Slovakia, Hong Kong, and the United Kingdom, which together represent a broad spectrum of media trust: Slovakia, a post-socialist country, exhibits persistently low media trust; Hong Kong shows relatively high and rising trust despite declining media freedom; and the United Kingdom occupies an intermediate position with declining trust. We interpret these patterns in relation to political culture, drawing on the modified methodology of Almond and Verba, and emphasize that the concept of trust should be understood as a context-dependent evaluative opinion rather than a uniform measure across societies. Based on this analysis, we propose a classification of three varieties of trust toward media. This framework has important implications for understanding public trust in AI-mediated news, as decision-makers cannot treat trust as a constant variable across political contexts without careful consideration of its underlying meanings.

Our novel approach contributes directly to the objectives of WG1 (Theory) by clarifying how opinions are expressed and understood in digital information environments, spanning journalism studies, discourse studies, media policy, political communication, and information science. The interdisciplinary methodology of our research combines media studies, political philosophy, philosophy of language, and moral philosophy. Our conceptual classification of varieties of trust draws on philosophical methods for analyzing concepts, helping to clarify what different survey respondents mean by ‘trust’ in different national contexts. For instance, trust may reflect stability and predictability in Hong Kong, freedom from state control in Slovakia, or alignment with political stance in the UK. This framework complements empirical analysis and supports nuanced interpretation of opinions about both more traditional and AI-mediated news. This approach supports the development of normative recommendations concerning transparency, accountability, information justice, and responsible political communication, thereby contributing to Working Group 1’s aim of strengthening the theoretical foundations of opinion research within the OPINION Action and is highly relevant for broader spectrum of stakeholders including policy makers for using public opinions and trust in justifying decisions.

At the moment, we are refining the extended abstract and sending it to academic journal focusing on AI, public opinion, and democratic resilience. We are adjusting it to match the preferred IMRaD style of the journal as we communicated with editors. We actively cooperate further online on finalizing the article and possible follow ups – further publications on similar topics, further stays or possible joint project and research activities including using larger variety of methods including those learned by COST OPINION Training school.

The Oxford part of the stay was highly beneficial in shedding further light on the issues and enriching our perspective, including chilling effects, political philosophy, sociological, and ethical dimensions, as well as providing valuable feedback on the article's thesis. The contacts established during the stay also open promising opportunities for future collaboration with Oxford-based research institutes. Researchers at Oxford expressed interest in the final article and in exchanging research information, and they were receptive to invited lectures, future research stays, and sharing relevant contacts. Since the visit, I have maintained active communication with the Oxford institutes, followed their activities online, and held an online meeting to deepen collaboration on AI media trust research. I also established contact with F. M. Simon, Research Fellow in AI, Information, and News at the Reuters Institute, University of Oxford, who conducted a seminar after my stay on topics relevant to AI and media opinions. The STSM thus fulfils also planned goals to enhance cross-country and interdisciplinary dialogue on media and AI-generated news trust, supporting future collaborations and potential follow-up projects.